

INTRODUCTIONS AND CONCLUSIONS

Elevating your speech from good to great

What's all the fuss about intros and conclusions?



Introduction:

Can you imagine how strange a speech would sound without an introduction? Or if, a speaker just came up made a point and then sat down?

This is just one of the reasons all speeches need introductions and conclusions. Introductions and conclusions serve to frame the speech and give it a clearly defined beginning and end. They help the audience to see what is to come in the speech, and then let them mentally prepare for the end.

Structuring your introduction

You may be wondering what words will be memorable, attention-capturing, and clever enough to get their audience interested or, really just, sound good.

There isn't any one "best" way to start a speech, but we will discuss some helpful guidelines that will make starting a speech much easier. No matter what style you use, there are five basic elements that you will want to incorporate into your introduction. Your introduction should:

- Grab the audience's attention.
- Establish or Enhance Your Credibility: your audience needs to know that you are a knowledgeable and credible source for this information.
- Establish rapport with the audience
- Preview your topic/purpose/central idea
- Preview your main points

Spotlight:
The Attention grabber.

An attention grabber raises the audience's interest in what you have to say at the very beginning of a speech.



You need to make sure that the option you choose is actually appropriate and relevant to your specific audience. Different audiences will have different backgrounds and knowledge, so you should use your audience analysis to determine whether specific information you plan on using would be appropriate for a specific audience.

Some examples of attention getters that you may find useful for opening your speech:

- Anecdote: An anecdote is a brief account or story of an interesting or humorous event
- Startling Statement/Statistic/Fact
- A rhetorical question: this is a question that does not require an answer
- Reference to Audience or Appeal to Self-Interest, or to a current event
- A quotation or historical reference
- Humor

Structuring your conclusion

Similar to the introduction, the conclusion has three specific elements that you will want to incorporate in order to make it as strong as possible.

- Signal the end; you cannot just stop without some type of signal
- Restate your main points; summarise what you've talked about.
- End with something memorable, sometimes called a clincher.

Spotlight: The Clincher.

Sometimes referred to as a Concluding Device, his is the last thing your audience will hear, so you want to make it good.

The clincher is like the opposite of the attention getter. You want to start the speech off with something strong, and you want to end the speech with something strong.

Here are a number of ways you can make your clincher strong and memorable:

- Conclude with a challenge i.e. a call to engage in some kind of activity that requires a special effort
- Conclude with a quotation.
- Conclude by Visualizing the Future
- Conclude with a Question
- Refer Back to the Introduction
- Conclude with an Anecdote or Personal Story

Common errors to avoid

The general rule is that the introduction and conclusion should each be about 10% of your total speech, leaving 80% for the body section.

Consequently, there are some common errors to avoid in introductions:

- rambling and meandering, not getting to the point;
- Speaking off-point to become comfortable;
- beginning to talk as you approach the platform or lectern; instead, it is preferable to reach your destination, pause, smile, and then begin;
- reading your introduction from your notes; instead, it is vital to establish eye contact in the introduction, so knowing it very well is important;
- talking too fast; instead, let your audience get used to your voice by speaking emphatically and clearly.

Common errors to avoid

In terms of the conclusions, be careful NOT to:

- signal the end multiple times. In other words, no “multiple conclusions” or saying “As I close” more than once;
- rambling; if you signal the end, end;
- talking as you leave the platform or lectern
- indicating with facial expression or body language that you were not happy with the speech.